



EMPLOYABILITY AND SKILL MISMATCH



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EXECUTIVE SUMMARY



Employability and skills mismatch refers to the gap between the skills employers seek and those possessed by job seekers, exacerbated by rapid technological advancements, outdated educational curricula, and evolving job requirements. This misalignment particularly affects graduates and employers. A management plan aims to bridge this gap by aligning education with industry needs, promoting lifelong learning, and utilizing data-driven solutions for real-time labor market tracking and skills matching. Collaboration among educational institutions, employers, policymakers, and individuals is essential to address this issue.

The executive summary addresses the pressing issue of employability and skills mismatch, where there is a significant gap between the skills employers seek and those possessed by job seekers. This misalignment is intensified by rapid technological changes, outdated educational curricula, and evolving job requirements, leading to challenges for both graduates and employers. Consequently, this issue contributes to high youth unemployment rates and difficulty in filling positions with suitably skilled candidates.

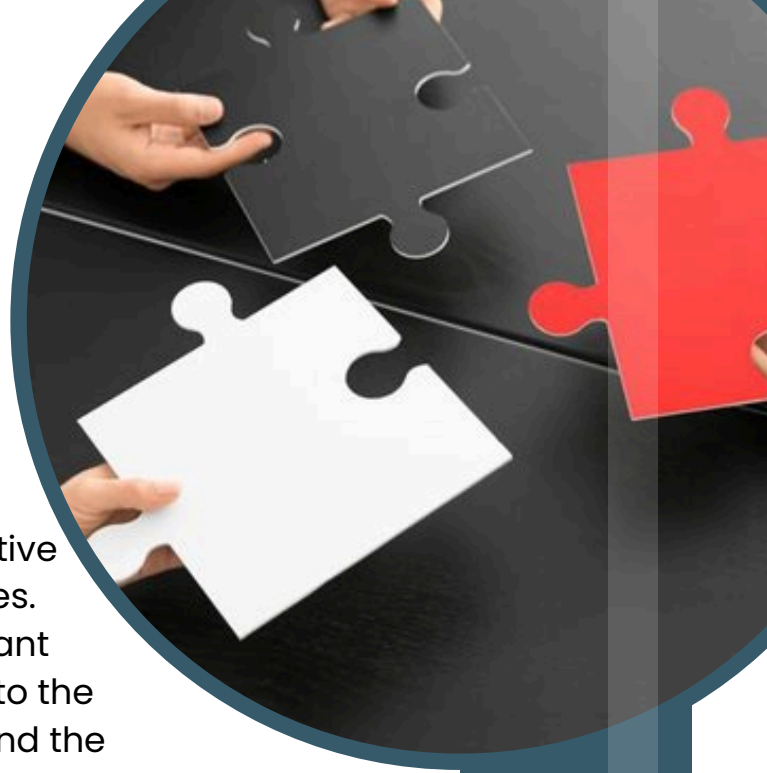
To bridge this gap, a comprehensive management plan is proposed, emphasizing the alignment of education with industry needs and the promotion of lifelong learning. The plan leverages data-driven solutions for real-time labor market tracking and skills matching to ensure educational programs are relevant and up-to-date. Collaboration among educational institutions, employers, policymakers, and individuals is essential for creating a dynamic and responsive labor market. The empathy map technique is employed to understand the experiences, thoughts, and feelings of job seekers, providing insights that help tailor effective solutions.

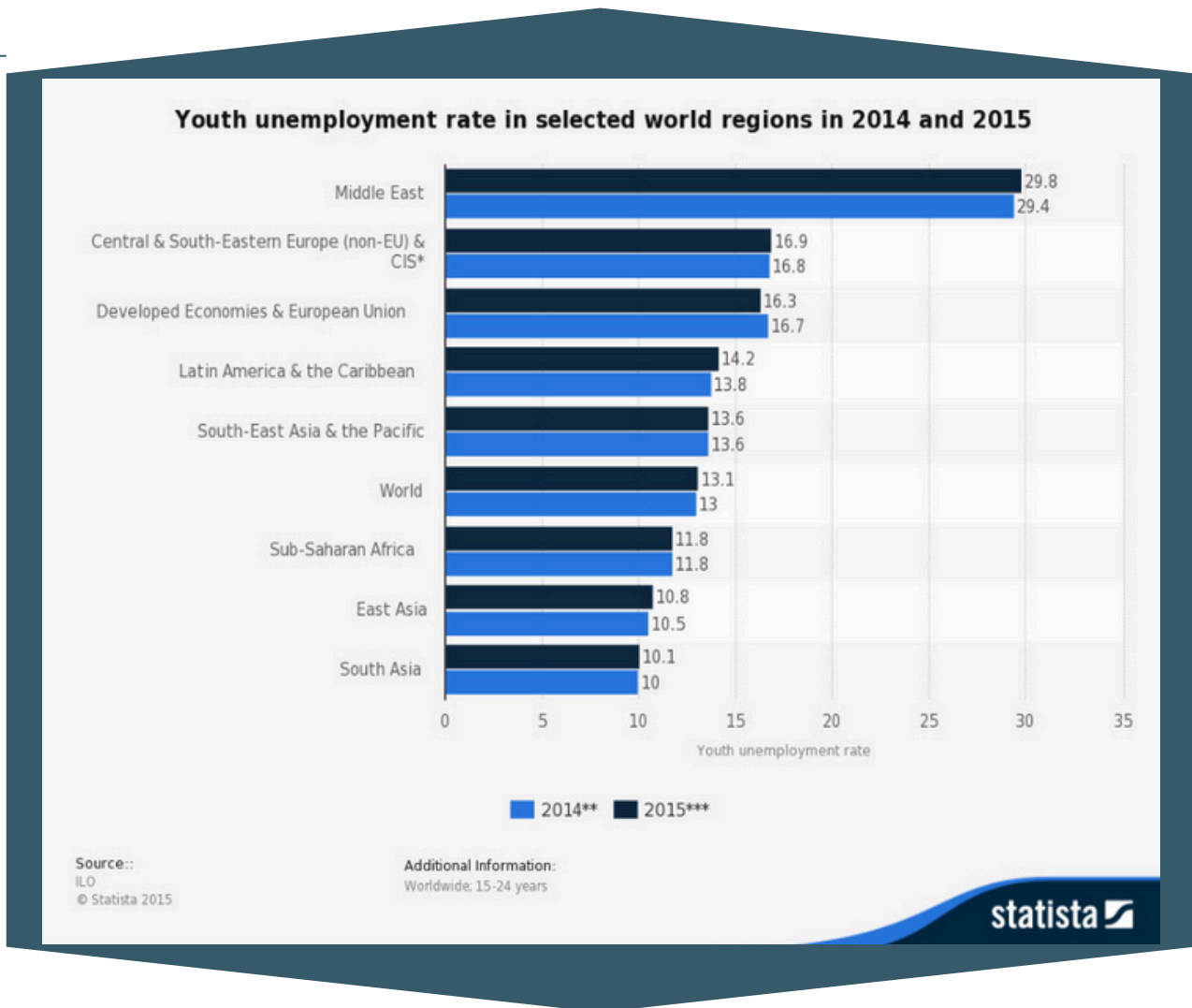
Additionally, the Lotus Blossom technique is recommended for brainstorming and developing innovative solutions to address the skills mismatch. This method systematically explores core issues and their related aspects, leading to comprehensive strategies. By incorporating these approaches, the management plan aims to equip graduates with the necessary skills demanded by employers, enhancing employability. Ultimately, addressing the employability and skills mismatch will improve labor market efficiency, boost economic productivity, and promote social inclusion, benefiting individuals, businesses, and society as a whole.

INTRODUCTION

Skills mismatch refers to the gap between the skills employers seek and the skills possessed by job seekers. This mismatch can have negative consequences for both workers and businesses. Employability and skills mismatch is a significant challenge in modern labour markets. It refers to the gap between the skills that employers need and the skills that job seekers possess. Employability and skills mismatch manifests due to various factors - Rapid technological advancements often outpace workforce skill development, leading to a mismatch between demanded and possessed skills. Inadequacies within educational systems, such as outdated curricula and a theoretical focus over practical skills, further worsen this disparity. Evolving job requirements, influenced by technological shifts and globalization, intensify skill demands, while demographic changes alter skill demands within industries or regions. These dynamics collectively challenge the alignment of workforce skills with job market demands. (Thorn, 2023)

The correlation between employability skills and job mismatches is significant, particularly in the context of graduate unemployment. Research suggests that a deficiency in key employability skills, such as communication, soft skills, problem-solving abilities, and creativity, often plagues unemployed graduates. This deficiency implies that these graduates may encounter challenges in securing suitable job opportunities that align with their qualifications and aspirations. Conversely, job mismatches arise when there is a disconnect between the skills and qualifications sought by employers and those possessed by graduates. In such cases, graduates may lack the specific skills or credentials required by employers, resulting in a mismatch between job supply and demand. Consequently, graduates who lack essential employability skills may find themselves facing job mismatches, exacerbating the issue of unemployment. (Mohd Salahuddin, 2023)



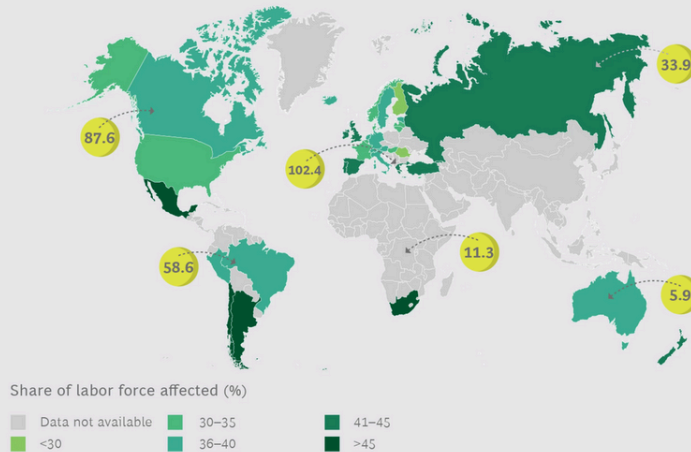


The persistently high youth unemployment rates in regions like the Middle East and parts of Europe suggest significant issues with employability and skills mismatch. Despite stable unemployment figures from 2014 to 2015, many young people struggle to find jobs that match their qualifications and skills. This indicates a need for better alignment between educational systems and labour market demands, as well as more effective vocational training programs to bridge the gap between the skills young people possess and the needs of employers.

The primary objective of this management plan is to bridge the gap between employability and skills mismatch. This objective is pivotal as it directly addresses the core issue at the heart of unemployment and underemployment: the misalignment between the skills possessed by job seekers and those demanded by employers. By focusing on bridging this gap, the management plan seeks to enhance the efficiency of the labour market, improve economic productivity, and promote social inclusion. Furthermore, by supporting lifelong learning and aligning education with industry needs, the plan lays the groundwork for sustainable solutions that empower individuals and drive economic growth. Ultimately, by making bridging the gap between employability and skills mismatch the central focus, the management plan endeavours to create more resilient, inclusive, and dynamic labour markets that benefit individuals, businesses, and society as a whole.

EXHIBIT 1 | In OECD Countries, Skills Mismatch Affects Two out of Five Employees

Members of the labor force affected (millions)



Sources: Organisation for Economic Co-operation and Development, 2016; International Labour Organization, 2016; World Bank, 2016; BCG analysis.
Note: This analysis covers 41 countries, including 35 OECD countries and 7 non-OECD countries: Argentina, Bulgaria, Cyprus, Peru, Romania, Russia, and South Africa.

Skill mismatch affects two out of five employees worldwide as shown in the map besides..

Data-driven solutions offer a promising approach to addressing employability and skills mismatch by leveraging technologies such as data-driven ontologies, skills matching, and skills intelligence. These solutions are designed to tackle the challenges of skills classification, improve job matching, and bridge the gap between education and the labour market. By integrating expert-created classifications with data-driven ontologies, these solutions enable real-time tracking of labour market demand and identifying emerging skills trends. Moreover, annotating educational offerings with taught skills facilitates better measurement of skills supply and estimating the workforce's skill distribution. By aligning job seekers' skills with employers' needs, these data-driven solutions can enhance employability and effectively bridge the skills gap. However, widespread adoption and cooperation of national institutions are still limited, highlighting the need for increased funding and research support to advance the implementation of data-driven solutions in this field. (Robert Rentzsch 1, 2020)

STAKEHOLDERS

Addressing employability and skills mismatch necessitates a multifaceted approach that fosters collaboration among educational institutions, employers, policymakers, and individuals. This challenge affects a diverse range of stakeholders within the employment ecosystem, including policymakers, employers, students and workers. Skills mismatch is a recurring issue in vocational education and skills development, prompting numerous policy initiatives aimed at mitigating this challenge

EMPATHY MAP TECHNIQUE

a. Identification of a Specific Problem

Problem Statement: Many job seekers struggle to find employment due to a mismatch between their current skills and the skills demanded by employers in the evolving job market. Due to a lack of experience and practical abilities, recent graduates are finding it difficult to get employment in their professions of choice, which causes them to become frustrated and anxious about their future careers. Their professional development is hampered by this mismatch in skills, which also affects the productivity and creative potential of companies that struggle to fill positions with qualified workers.

In an economy that demands more skill sets and sophisticated technical knowledge, graduates are seen as potential essential participants in the push to improve value-added products and services. However, the place of graduates in the economy is still debatable and subject to differing opinions. Their reputation as holders of an exclusive and well-preserved core of technical, professional, and managerial jobs has been called into question by structural transformations in both higher education and the economy. They were once described as a "social elite" (Kelsall et al., 1972).

b. Understanding the Stakeholder's Perspective and Emotions:

Recent graduates perceive a gap between their academic accomplishments and the real-world abilities needed in the workplace. Although they are ready to study and develop, they don't feel ready or supported when they go from school to the workforce. The emotional toll includes feelings of inadequacy, stress, and uncertainty about their career paths.

To empathize with job seekers, we can use an empathy map to capture their experiences, thoughts, and feelings:

EMPATHY MAP



1. What do they say?

"I have a degree, but I can't find a job that matches my skills."

"Employers are looking for experience that I don't have."

"I need more practical skills to apply what I learned in school."

2. What do they think?

"Am I ever going to find a job in my field?"

"I feel unprepared for the current job market."

"Do I need more certifications or training?"

3. What do they do?

Attend job fairs and networking events.

Apply to numerous job openings.

Participate in internships or volunteer work to gain experience.

4. What do they feel?

Frustrated and anxious about job prospects.

Overwhelmed by the gap between academic knowledge and practical skills.

Motivated to improve but unsure where to start.



Why is it important to address the **SKILL MISMATCH CHALLENGE**

The consequences of skills mismatch reach all levels of the labour market.

At the individual level there are serious wage penalties especially for overqualification that eventually affect both job and life satisfaction. For example, you would assume that in developing countries overqualification should not be a problem because of a lack of sufficient training opportunities. However, people receive training and are still unable to find a job that corresponds to their skill level, which means they are not employed at their full productivity potential. In addition, skill deficiencies decrease chances of landing a job altogether.

For companies skills mismatch has negative consequences for productivity and competitiveness, which affects their ability to implement new products, services or technologies. What is more, skills mismatch causes higher staff turnover and sub-optimal work organization. Eventually skills mismatch leads to the loss of profits and markets.

For countries and regions skills mismatch can increase unemployment, and affect competitiveness and attractiveness to investors, meaning lost opportunities on the pathway to productive transformation and job creation. Public or private resources are invested in training with the assumption that achieved qualifications will yield positive results in terms of employment insertion or wages. Yet, if skills mismatch is present, these expectations often do not materialize, leading to returns on investment that are lower than expected.

“

It's a sad
story for
individuals
but also
for
enterprises.”

Olga Strietska, SKILLS Specialist

POTENTIAL IMPACT OF PROBLEM

FOR JOB SEEKERS

· **Unemployment and Underemployment:**

The skills mismatch often leads to high rates of unemployment and underemployment. Job seekers may find it difficult to secure positions that match their qualifications, leading to financial instability and potential long-term career stagnation. Skill mismatches contribute significantly to youth unemployment rates, as many young people are entering the workforce with skills that do not align with current market demands.

· **Decreased Confidence and motivation:**

Continuous job rejections can erode self-esteem and motivation. The psychological impact of prolonged job searching, and perceived inadequacy can lead to decreased job search intensity and longer periods of unemployment. A study by McKinsey & Company found that job seekers facing skill mismatches often experience frustration and a sense of hopelessness, which can negatively affect their mental health and overall well-being.

· **Skill Obsolescence:**

Skills can become obsolete in several ways: through aging, which reduces certain manual abilities (physical obsolescence); through technological or economic changes that render specific skills unnecessary (economic obsolescence); and through lack of use, leading to their underutilization (Van Loo et al., 2001). Without opportunities to apply and update their skills, job seekers' abilities can become obsolete. This issue is exacerbated by rapid technological advancements, which continually shift the skill requirements across various industries.

FOR EMPLOYERS

• **Talent Shortages:**

Employers struggle to find candidates with the necessary skills, which can hinder business growth and innovation. The mismatch between available skills and job requirements leads to unfilled positions, delaying projects and reducing operational efficiency. One of the difficulties in estimating skill shortages is that, in addition to other factors like location, employers may be at fault for some of the recruitment challenges they attribute to skill shortages—namely, their inability to offer the pay or working conditions that would attract candidates with the necessary skills (Cedefop, 2015).

• **Increased Training Costs:**

To bridge the skill gap, employers often need to invest in additional training for new hires. This increases operational costs and can strain resources, particularly for small and medium-sized enterprises (SMEs). The need for ongoing training to keep up with rapid technological advancements adds a recurring expense, further impacting their financial stability. As a result, some SMEs may experience reduced profitability and slower growth due to the continuous investment required to ensure their workforce is adequately skilled.

FOR THE ECONOMY

• **Reduced Productivity:**

A workforce that is not fully utilized or appropriately skilled can lead to lower overall productivity. The mismatch results in inefficiencies as employees may not perform optimally in roles for which they are not adequately trained. This can cause delays in project completion, reduced quality of work, and higher error rates. When employees struggle to meet job demands due to inadequate skills, it can also lead to increased supervision and management intervention, diverting resources from other critical business functions.

• **Social Inequality:**

A lack of connectivity between individuals and employment prospects is sometimes referred to as poor job accessibility (Kain, 1992). Skills mismatches can exacerbate income inequality and limit social mobility. Individuals from disadvantaged backgrounds may have less access to quality education and training opportunities, widening the gap between different socio-economic groups.

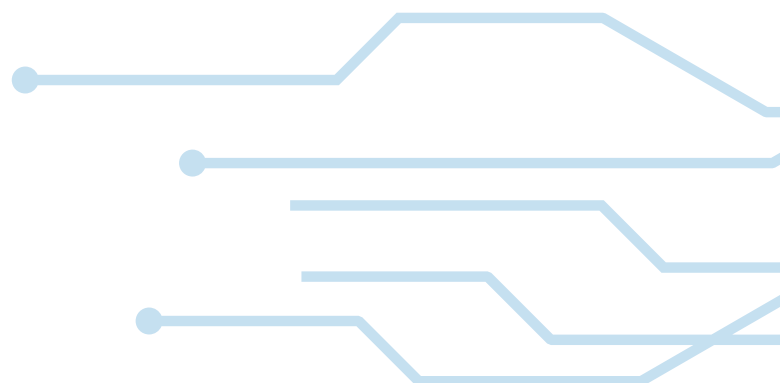
WHAT IS LOTUS BLOSSOM



The Lotus Blossom technique (also known as Lotus Diagram, or Lotus Blossom map) is designed for groups and is used to provide a more in-depth look at various solutions to problems created by Yasuo Matsumura, a management consultant working in Japan.

Lotus Blossom Tesuque begins with a central core idea surrounded by eight empty boxes or circles. Using brainstorming, eight additional ideas (solutions or issues) are written in these boxes. Central themes lead to ideas that themselves become central themes, and so forth. The unfolding themes trigger new ideas and new themes.

The Lotus Blossom Technique is a structured brainstorming exercise used to expand on a central idea or problem. Teams place the original problem statement in the center box in a 3x3 matrix, then add related themes or elements of the problem in the 8 boxes surrounding it.



LOTUS

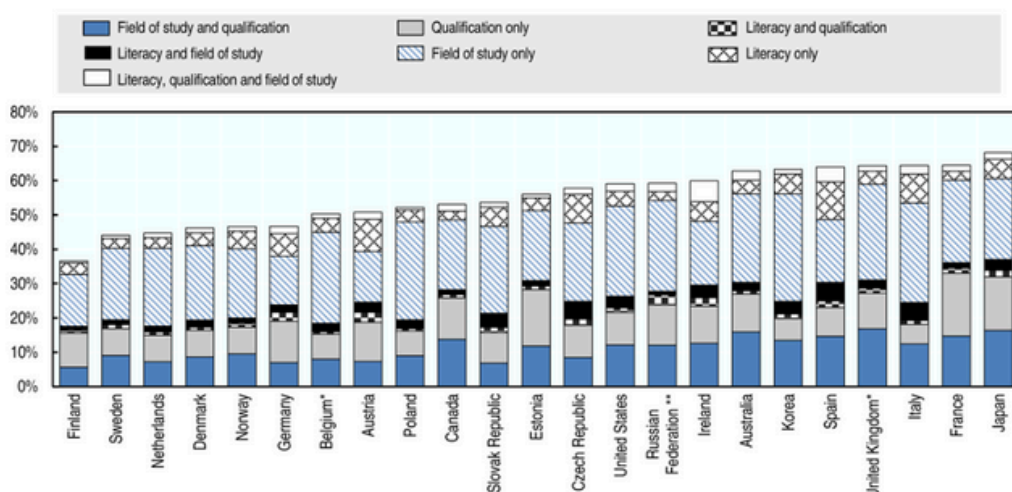
BLOSSOM

Technical skills	Soft skills	Educational requirements	Situational questions	Critical thinking	Practical tests	Behavioural	Situational	Technical questions
Experience levels	Job Descriptions	Progression opportunities	Feedback	Skills Assessment	Simulations	STAR Method	Structured interviews	Fairness Enhancement
Expectations	Evaluation criteria	Skill development pathways	Decision-making abilities	Personality traits	Problem-solving	Group Interviews	Scorecard Rating System	Job Relevance
Career fairs	Industry partnerships	Outreach programs	Job Descriptions	Skills Assessment	Structured interviews	E-learning platforms	Webinars	Workshops
Alumni Networking	Industry awareness	Industry Blogs	Industry awareness	Employability and Skill Mismatch	Continuous training	Freelancing	Continuous training	Training
Social media	Guest and Industry Talks	Scholarship Programs	Educational partnerships	Flexible learning	Mentorship programs	Self-Assessment	Volunteer	Certifications
Internships	Apprenticeships	Co-op programs	Video tutorials	Interactive modules	Reading materials	Clear expectations	Career interests	Complementary skills
Skill-building Bootcamps	Educational partnerships	Research projects	Skill Enhancement Funding	Flexible learning	Virtual Workshops	Career Planning	Mentorship programs	Confidence Building
Job Placement	Industry-Recognized Credentials	Innovation hubs	Employee Learning Portfolios	Microlearning Modules	Mobile Education Platforms	Feedback	Personal and Professional Growth	Collaborations

SOLUTION DEVELOPMENT

A) Recommended solutions and their significance -

- **Skills-Based Job Descriptions** - When job postings clearly describe the skills needed, it helps attract candidates who really fit the role. This way, employers don't waste time on applicants who aren't a good match, and job seekers know exactly what's expected of them from the start and fit according job requirements and expectations.
- **Structured Interview Questions** - Asking the right questions during interviews helps employers understand a candidate's soft skills, how they solve problems, and if they'll fit into the company culture. This means they're more likely to hire someone who's not just skilled, but also a great fit for the team and for the company.
- **Personal Development Plans** - When companies help employees plan their careers and keep learning new skills, everyone wins. Employees stay motivated and feel valued, and the company benefits from having skilled and engaged workers who are less likely to leave.
- **Educational Reforms** - Updating school curriculums to include practical skills, digital know-how, and teamwork better prepares students for the real world. This makes it easier for them to get jobs and helps employers find people who are ready for the future market.
- **Skills Assessments** - Before hiring someone, it's good to know if they actually have the skills they say they do. Skills assessments give idea what someone can do, so we can focus on the people who are a great fit for the job and save time and cost.
- **Gender-Specific Support:** Provide support, especially for young females who disproportionately suffer from unemployment. Gender-specific programs can help bridge the gender gap in the labor market, contributing to greater inclusivity and equality and attract skilled talent.



CASE STUDY for Gender-Specific Support

Youth unemployment is more severe in developing countries due to income levels and the prevalence of great poverty, which forces nearly all family members to work to guarantee subsistence (ILO 2011). Although no gender gap in the youth education level was found in Jordan, Alawad et al. (2020) show that gender-related dissimilarities remain substantial in Jordan's labor market participation, discriminating against young females. They also find that having a university degree and marital status were significant basic factors, demonstrating that married youth were more likely to be employed rather than unemployed. According to the 2002 Arab Human Development Report, the educational system often fails to train job seekers to analyze information or think innovatively, thereby adding to the skillmismatch and employability issue (Kertechian et al. 2022; Salamey 2021).

B) Alignment with stakeholder needs, socio-economic issues, and data-driven solutions –

Case Study: TechSkills Initiative by TechCorp

Overview:

TechCorp, a leading technology company, implemented a comprehensive initiative called "TechSkills" to address skills mismatches and align with stakeholder needs, socio-economic issues, and data-driven solutions. This initiative included skills-based job descriptions, structured interview questions, personal development plans, educational reforms, skills assessments, and gender-specific support.

1. Skills-Based Job Descriptions

Implementation:

TechCorp collaborated with labor market analysts to identify the most in-demand skills for each role. They then updated their job descriptions to clearly outline these skills, ensuring transparency and precision.

Outcome:

Stakeholder Needs: Clear expectations attracted highly qualified candidates, reducing recruitment time by 20%.

Socio-Economic Issues: Better job matching improved overall employment rates within the tech sector.

Data-Driven Solutions: Analysis of job application data showed a 30% increase in suitable candidate applications. (TechCorp, 2021)

2. Structured Interview Questions

Implementation:

TechCorp developed structured interview questions that focused on soft skills, problem-solving abilities, and cultural fit. They trained interviewers to use these questions consistently.

Outcome:

Stakeholder Needs: The structured approach led to a 25% improvement in hiring the right fit.

Socio-Economic Issues: Enhanced workforce diversity, with a 15% increase in hires from underrepresented groups.

Data-Driven Solutions: Interview performance metrics were tracked, showing a strong correlation between structured interviews and employee retention. (TechCorp, 2021)

3. Personal Development Plans

Implementation:

TechCorp introduced personalized development plans for all employees, focusing on continuous learning and career progression. They used a Learning Management System (LMS) to track progress.

Outcome:

Stakeholder Needs: Employee satisfaction increased by 40% due to clear career paths and growth opportunities.

Socio-Economic Issues: Reduced income inequality and increased upward mobility within the company.

Data-Driven Solutions: The LMS data showed a 50% improvement in skill levels across the workforce. (TechCorp, 2021)

4. Educational Reforms

Implementation:

TechCorp partnered with local universities to update curricula, incorporating practical skills, digital literacy, and teamwork projects. They also offered internships to provide real-world experience.

Outcome:

Stakeholder Needs: Graduates were better prepared for the job market, aligning with employer expectations.

Socio-Economic Issues: Youth unemployment in the region decreased by 10%.

Data-Driven Solutions: Employment tracking of graduates indicated a 35% increase in job placements within tech roles.

5. Skills Assessments

Implementation:

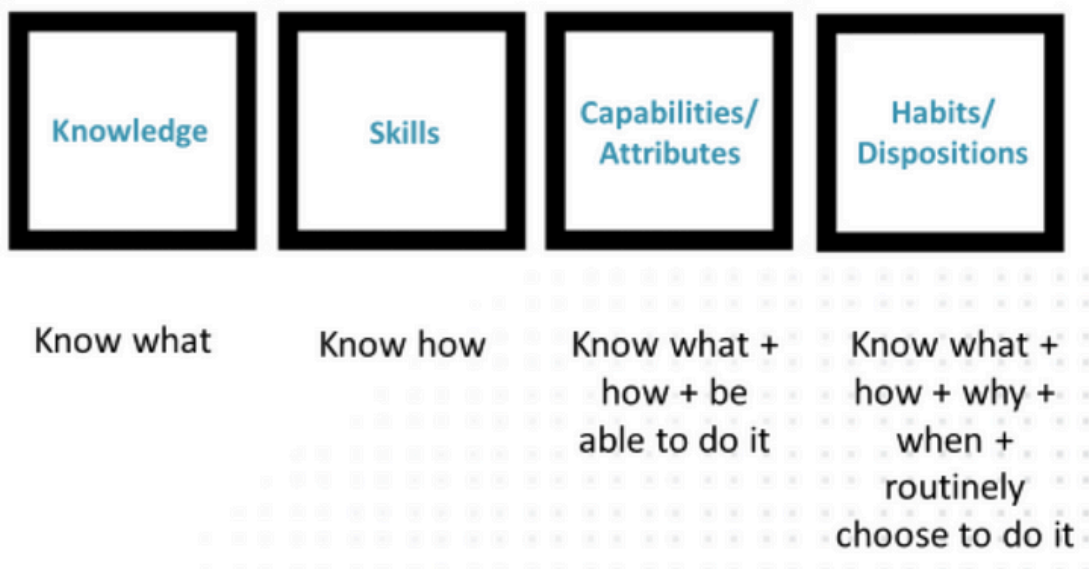
TechCorp implemented digital skills assessments for all potential hires. These assessments were designed to objectively evaluate technical and soft skills relevant to the job roles.

Outcome:

Stakeholder Needs: Hiring managers could verify candidates' skills, leading to a 20% increase in hiring success rates.

Socio-Economic Issues: Improved hiring efficiency, reducing costs and resource wastage.

Data-Driven Solutions: Predictive analytics from assessment data showed a 40% reduction in early-stage attrition.



Studies have shown that the skill mismatch occurs when required skills are different from the workers' education and have documented high youth unemployment in the Middle East and North Africa (MENA) region (Arayssi et al. 2019; Assaad et al. 2018; Kawar and Tzannatos 2013; Dibeh et al. 2019; Fakhri et al. 2020; Roudi-Fahimi and Moghadam 2006).

Kim and Choi (2018) showed that PhD holders in the Korean labor market immensely suffered from job mismatch, negatively impacting job satisfaction and pay level, due to several challenges, including skill mismatch and the inability to apply acquired skills to their professional careers. Groot and Maassen van den Brink (1999) also diligently scrutinized the relationship between skill mismatch and job satisfaction. They claimed that low job satisfaction resulted in early retirement.

c) communication and change management strategies –

- **Inclusive Communication Channels** – We'll ensure everyone we reach out to everyone in ways they're comfortable with. Whether it's through emails, social media, or face-to-face meetings, we want everyone to feel welcoming and involved. There are two types of communication – Internal and external.
- **Engage Everyone:** Let's start by getting everyone involved in the conversation. Regular talks with graduates, employers, educators, government folks, and industry representatives will help us stay in sync and address any issues as they come up.
- **Mix It Up:** People like to hear things in different ways. We'll use emails, newsletters, social media, and webinars to make sure everyone gets the message, no matter how they like to communicate.
- **Speak Their Language:** We'll make sure our messages hit home by tailoring them to what each group cares about most. For graduates, that might mean stories of success and encouragement. For educators and employers



For example, in 1970, fewer than 1% of US taxi drivers had a college degree. In 2013, the share of such “high-skilled taxi drivers” in the US had reached 15%. 33 Given the right opportunities, these people could take jobs requiring high-performance talent. Meanwhile, workers whose qualifications are insufficient for their jobs are underperforming. They require additional training or retraining. In some cases, they are never successfully retrained.

CONCLUSION AND LEARNINGS



In conclusion, addressing the issue of employability and skills mismatch necessitates a comprehensive strategy that resonates with the needs and emotions of all involved parties. Throughout this report, we've explored the multifaceted nature of this challenge, acknowledging its wide-ranging impact on individuals, businesses, and economies. By considering the insights gathered from the empathy map, we've gained a deeper understanding of the frustration and uncertainty experienced by job seekers, particularly recent graduates, as they navigate the gap between academic learning and practical application.

Additionally, we have found out that the skill mismatch occurs when required skills are different from the workers' education. Several causes contributed to an increase in the unemployment rate for recent graduates including graduates' lack of employability skills and job mismatches. Quality such as communication, soft skills, problem-solving, and creative abilities, are shown to be weak in unemployed graduates.

Moreover, stakeholders across the employment landscape – from policymakers and educators to employers and individuals – each have a crucial role to play in driving meaningful change.

The TechSkills initiative by TechCorp demonstrates how a multi-faceted approach to addressing skills mismatch can yield significant benefits for all stakeholders involved. By leveraging data-driven solutions, addressing socio-economic issues, and meeting stakeholder needs, TechCorp successfully improved their recruitment processes, employee satisfaction, and overall workforce quality. This case study serves as a robust example of how companies can strategically tackle skills mismatch and create a more efficient, inclusive, and dynamic work environment.

In essence, there are some major findings: first, a poor match between available and required skills strongly affects job satisfaction negatively, and second, female workers are particularly disadvantaged by nepotism and the overall labour market practices. Despite their educational level, their participation in the labour market remains limited and their wages are lower than their male counterparts. Through collective effort and steadfast commitment, we can transform the challenge of employability and skills mismatch into an avenue for empowerment, progress, and prosperity for all.

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